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- **Meta**: CIPP vs pipe bursting: both are trenchless, but they solve different problems. Learn how each method works and which one fits your damaged sewer line.

CIPP vs. Pipe Bursting: Which Pipe Lining Method Do You Need?

Trenchless sewer repair is not a single technique. The two methods you will hear about most are CIPP pipe lining and pipe bursting. Both avoid digging a trench across your property, but they work very differently and fit different situations.

Here is how each one works and how contractors decide between them. If you are new to the topic, our pillar guide on what trenchless sewer repair i and how it works is a good starting point.

What Is CIPP Pipe Lining?

CIPP stands for cured-in-place pipe. The existing sewer line stays where it is and gets a new pipe built inside it.

The process starts with a sewer camera inspection to confirm the line is a candidate. The pipe is then cleaned, typically with hydro jetting, so the liner can bond properly. A resin-saturated liner is installed inside the existing pipe and cured in place, hardening into a new structural liner that seals cracks, open joints, and root entry points.

CIPP is often called sewer line lining or rehabilitation, because it restores the pipe you already have rather than replacing it.

What Is Pipe Bursting?

Pipe bursting is trenchless replacement rather than rehabilitation. A cone-shaped bursting head is pulled through the old pipe, fracturing it outward into the surrounding soil while simultaneously pulling a brand-new pipe into the space behind it.

Pipe bursting usually requires small access pits at each end of the run, but not a continuous trench. When it is done, the old pipe is gone in any functional sense and a new pipe has taken its path.

CIPP vs. Pipe Bursting: The Key Differences

- **Rehabilitation vs. replacement.** CIPP creates a new structural liner inside the old pipe. Pipe bursting breaks the old pipe apart and replaces it entirely.
- **Condition requirements.** CIPP needs a pipe that still holds its shape well enough to host a liner. Pipe bursting can handle lines too damaged to line, since the old pipe is destroyed anyway.
- **Access.** CIPP typically works through existing access points such as cleanouts. Pipe bursting generally needs entry and exit pits dug at the ends of the run.
- **Diameter.** A CIPP liner slightly reduces the interior diameter of the line, which rarely matters for residential flow. Pipe bursting can maintain or even upsize the pipe diameter.
- **Surrounding utilities.** Because bursting displaces soil outward, nearby utilities and structures have to be evaluated first. Lining stays inside the existing pipe and does not disturb the soil around it.

Which Method Fits Which Situation?

CIPP lining is usually the fit when:

- The pipe has cracks, open joints, corrosion, or root intrusion but still holds its general shape
- You want the least possible disturbance to the yard, driveway, and landscaping
- The line can be accessed through existing openings

Pipe bursting tends to come up when:

- The pipe is too deteriorated or deformed to accept a liner
- The line needs a larger diameter than it currently has
- Full replacement is required but excavating the entire run is impractical

And in some cases, neither trenchless method is right. Severe bellies or a need to correct the slope of the line can still call for targeted excavation. Our comparison of trenchless vs. traditional dig sewer repair covers when digging still wins.

Frequently Asked Questions

Is pipe bursting more disruptive than CIPP lining?

Generally somewhat more, since bursting needs access pits at the ends of the run and displaces soil as the new pipe is pulled through. Both are far less disruptive than open-trench excavation, but lining usually has the smallest footprint of all because it works through existing openings.

Can a pipe that was lined be lined again later?

The point of lining is that it seals the failure points that caused trouble in the first place, so the repaired section is designed for long-term service. Your contractor can verify liner condition with a camera inspection at any time, the same way the original pipe was evaluated.

What if my pipe has a belly or a slope problem?

Neither lining nor bursting fixes grade. A liner follows the existing path of the pipe, and bursting pulls the new pipe along the same route. If the camera finds a significant belly or slope issue, a targeted excavation of that section may be combined with trenchless repair for the rest of the line.

Which method costs less?

It depends on the length, depth, access, and condition of your specific line, which is why estimates follow inspections. The bigger cost difference is usually between either trenchless method and full excavation, where surface restoration adds a second project on top of the plumbing.

The Camera Decides, Not the Brochure

You cannot pick the right method from the surface. The deciding factors, including pipe shape, material condition, root intrusion, and access, are all underground, which is why every Alphalete project starts with an HD camera inspection.

Alphalete Trenchless Services specializes in CIPP trenchless pipe lining for homes and businesses across Colorado Springs, Denver, and surrounding communities. After the inspection, we explain what the camera found, whether your line is a good candidate for lining, and what the right repair path looks like, including when a different method would serve you better.

Schedule a free video inspection or call (720) 807-3224 to find out which trenchless method your sewer line actually needs.